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#METOO - Valley voters head to polls in first Assembly races since scandals

April 3, 2018 | Los Angeles Daily News (CA)
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In California's first elections of the #MeToo era, voters in parts of Los Angeles will go to the pollstoday to choose three new members of the state Assembly.

The two most closely watched special elections will be held in the San Fernando Valley to fill the remaining months of the terms of Democrats Raul Bocanegra and Matt Dababneh, who resigned from their Assembly seats late last year after women accused them of sexual misconduct.

The third will be held in Los Angeles, Culver City and Inglewood to fill out the term of Democrat Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who cited health problems in resigning from the Assembly at the end of last year.

Female candidates loom prominently in all three races at a time when more women than usual are running for offices of all kinds, a trend that's seen as a reaction to sexual harassment

scandals in government, women's anger at Trump administration policies, and backlash from Hillary Clinton's presidential election loss.

Whether voters will lean toward women intoday's elections isn't clear.

"The subset of voters who are likely to vote in a special election tend to be focused on other issues," said Tom Hogen-Esch, a political science professor at Cal State Northridge. "They're older, they're whiter, they're going to be more conservative than the area as a whole, and they're going be people who are directly impacted by the election, whether they're public employees or people with stakes in issues in the Legislature."

Special election results can be unpredictable, Hogen-Esch said, because relatively few voters participate. In recent years, stand-alone special elections in L.A. County have typically drawn less than 10 percent of registered voters.

Adding to the unpredictability is the brevity of the campaigns, only seven weeks from the release of the certified candidates list to election day.

Polls will be open from 7 a.m. to 8 p.m. Mail-in voting began March 6. L.A. County election information is available at lavote .net.

In each election, if any candidate receives more than 50 percent of the votes, he or she will be sworn in to serve until Dec. 3. If not, the top two intoday's returns will advance to a runoff on June 5. The primary for the next full two-year term in each Assembly office will also be held June 5 as part of a full ballot of statewide, state legislative and congressional contests.

In one of the three Assembly districts holding special elections, the potential for surprise is heightened by the presence of two unorthodox candidates.

That's District 45, covering the west San Fernando Valley communities of Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana and Encino and the Ventura County community of Bell Canyon. Eight candidates are seeking Dababneh's seat.

It's a heavily Democratic district — as are the other two — and six candidates are Democrats: attorney and leading

campaign fundraiser Jesse Gabriel, L.A. City Council aide Tricia Robbins Kasson, L.A. school board aide Ankur Patel, Ray Bishop, Jeff Bornstein and Daniel Brin. But the ballot also includes Republican Justin Clark, a 19-year-old Cal State Northridge student, and independent Dennis Zine, a conservative former L.A. city councilman who announced his withdrawal from the race in February but says he would serve if elected.

Despite his youth, Clark said he's "very confident" of finishing in the top two and making a runoff, in part because he believes he'll get most Republicans' votes while the Democratic candidates are splitting liberal votes.

Similar math could help Robbins Kasson, the only woman in the race.

In District 39, including the northeast San Fernando Valley communities of Arleta, Lake View Terrace, Mission Hills, North Hollywood, Pacoima, Sun Valley, Sunland-Tujunga, Sylmar and San Fernando, six candidates hope to replace Bocanegra.

Five of them are Democrats: former Assemblywoman Patty Lopez, engineer and educator Luz Rivas, union workforce development director Antonio Sanchez, former Assembly staffer and community volunteer Yolie Anguiano and documentary filmmaker Patrea Patrick. The lone Republican is Ricardo Benitez.

Lopez's presence is a reminder of the political surprises and turmoil that have become commonplace in the northeast Valley. A school and church volunteer and political novice, Lopez upset Bocanegra in the 2014 election and served two years in the Assembly before Bocanegra avenged the defeat in 2016.

In District 54, covering parts of L.A. and the Westside, four candidates vie to replace Ridley-Thomas. Three are Democrats: Sydney Kamlager, president of the L.A. Community College District Board of Trustees and the race's top fundraiser; Tepring Piquado, a neuroscientist and RAND Corp. policy analyst, and Grayson Pangilinan, a 23-year-old green energy entrepreneur. One is Republican: small-business owner Glen Ratcliff.

It's expected that one of the women will emerge as the winner.

Bocanegra and Dababneh are two of several California legislators — all L.A. County Democrats — accused of sexual harassment since allegations against Hollywood mogul Harvey Weinstein touched off the #MeToo movement of women speaking out about mistreatment by powerful men.

State Sen. Tony Mendoza of Arleta resigned in February amid harassment allegations but plans to run in a special election scheduled for June 5 in District 32. Sen. Bob Hertzberg of Van Nuys was reprimanded. Assemblywoman Cristina Garcia of Bell Gardens is under investigation.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Modesti, K. (2018, April 3). #METOO Valley voters head to polls in first Assembly races since scandals*Daily News of Los Angeles (CA)*, p. 1. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/16B0D2BD23B0F298.